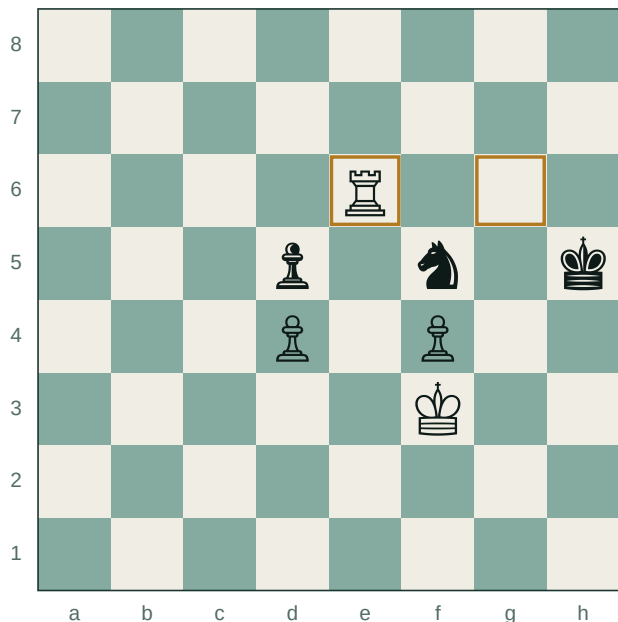


Active defensive resources: Black, move 53

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 53.Rxe6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

53...Nxd4+ 54. Ke3 Nxe6 55. f5 Nc7

53...Nxd4+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here. From d4 it attacks king on f3 and rook on e6. Recorded reply: **54.Ke3**.

54...Nxe6 The knight captures the rook on e6. Recorded reply: **55.f5**.

55...Nc7 The knight moves from e6 to c7.

At the end, nominal material is White 1 / Black 4 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -3 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on f3. Geometrically undefended: rook on e6. Check for tactical protection.